Title: Can a brand truly be managed?

Brand management is often regarded as a strategic control process in modern marketing. Aaker (1996) pointed out that“the establishment of a strong brand relies on clear brand identity positioning, which is communicated consistently to ensure every customer experience aligns with the intended brand message.”

This traditional perspective assumes that brands are stable assets, and their value can be managed by aligning image and identity.

However, with the rise of digital media and stakeholder engagement has changed this situation. As discussed in Lecture, brands have evolved into cultural systems that exist not only in corporate communication, but also in social media narratives. Scholars such as Holt (2004) and Arvidsson (2005) argue that brand meaning is no longer produced solely by organizations, but also co-created by audiences through interaction and cultural expression. The management of a brand, therefore, becomes a process of balance between control and freedom.

This essay argues that a brand can be strategically guided, but not entirely managed as what people used to think. While managers can influence brand direction through storytelling and communication, while culture and consumers together shape a brand’s meaning, which companies and managers can not fully control. To explore this argument, the essay will first review traditional viewpoint that brand can be managed, then contrast them with cultural and co-creation theories, and before analysing case studies to illustrate how brands function as a

“ living cultural ”. From the theoretical perspective, the essence of a brand lies not only in its economic function, but also in its cultural meaning. Traditionally, branding has been framed through the “brand as asset” perspective, which treats a brand as a measurable and manageable business resource. It’s a form of intangible property that adds value through recognition, consistency, and trust (Riezebos, 2003). Within this view, the brand is something an organization can design, position, and control through strategy and communication. It is managed through measurable metrics, such as awareness, equity and customer loyalty. This view treats the brand as a stable asset that the company can manage and adjust to increase profit. It reflects a marketing logic that prioritizes efficiency and consistency.

Scholars such as Adam Arvidsson (2005) and Weiser (2012) argue that this view is too narrow. It ignores the social and cultural factors that give brands their vitality. From the “brand as cultural system” perspective, a brand is not just a controlled asset but a living system rooted in everyday life and public conversation. It serves as a shared space where companies and consumers negotiate and create its meaning.

Holt (2004) describes brands as “cultural texts” that reflect how society express identity and desire. Arvidsson (2005) adds that brand value rises from consumer participation. He calls this process “ethical surplus”, where communities generate meanings that extend beyond managerial control.

In this view, their ideas align with the cultural perspective that a brand functions as a living cultural system—one that can be guided but never fully controlled. Meaning is co-created through interactions among consumers, communities, and shared social values, not produced by corporations alone. Public discussions, memes, fan cultures, and even criticism all shape what a brand becomes. Thus, management shifts from control to guidance, allowing meaning to grow naturally through collective participation.

This shift is reflected in Jeff Bezos's famous remark: "Your brand is what people say about you when you're not in the room." The quote captures the essence of co-created meaning : brands ultimately live in the minds, conversations, and emotions of the public. From this view, authenticity, trust, and cultural resonance matter more than strict management control. A brand's success depends on its ability to engage with social narratives and allow audiences to take part in value co-creation.

In conclusion, a brand's essence is both economic and cultural. As an asset, it can be organized, measured, and managed. Yet as a cultural system, it remains dynamic, shared, and shaped by collective imagination. In today's fast-changing media environment, the most enduring brands succeed by balancing strategy with openness—guiding direction while embracing co-creation, dialogue, and cultural evolution.

From a cultural and social perspective, a brand is not merely a managerial asset but a living meaning system, which embedded within everyday discourse. Rather than being entirely designed and controlled by corporations, brand meaning constantly circulates and transforms the company's intentions as it interacts with society. In this view, a brand is a place where culture, consumers, and communities work together to shape its meaning. The process is dynamic and dialogical — meaning is co-created through public conversations, media representations, and user practices rather than imposed from above.

This perspective shifts attention from control to cultural meaning. A brand's strength lies in its emotional and social connection with people, not in consistency or efficiency. Brands act as social discourses that reflect and reproduce broader cultural values, ideologies, and desires. For example, brands like Nike and Apple serve as cultural texts expressing empowerment, creativity, and individualism that extend beyond their products. Online spaces amplify this process, as fans, influencers, and communities reshape brand messages through memes, art, and storytelling. Such shared participation keeps a brand's meaning open, fluid, and diverse. A good example is Gucci's #TFWGucci meme campaign (2017). The brand invited Internet users to create memes using its official images, blending luxury fashion with online humor (See Appendix A). People turned Gucci's high-end image into something fun and relatable through jokes and self-mockery. Though many creations exceeded the brand's plan, the campaign sparked huge online engagement and refreshed Gucci's image. This shows that brand meaning is fluid and shaped by users, proving that cultural energy comes from openness, not control.

Under this situation, brand management becomes a process of guidance rather than total control. Managers can propose narratives, design symbols, and communities, but they can not dictate how these meanings will evolve once they enter the social media. Meaning is created together through ongoing exchange between creators and audiences, shaped by history, media, and culture. As Holt (2004) and Arvidsson (2005) argue, brands thrive when they become part of collective identity formation, when users find personal or social significance in them. So, while strategy sets direction, it doesn't fix the result. A brand can be guided by stories and symbols, but it can't be fully controlled. Its value comes from cultural life — how people keep reinterpreting it. From this view, branding becomes a shared process of meaning, built through the stories people tell.

When it comes to stakeholder complexity and co-creation, in the contemporary media environment, brands operate within a dynamic ecosystem where meaning, value, and trust are co-created through interaction among multiple stakeholders. Instead of a top-down system, a brand is now a living process shaped by ongoing dialogue among consumers, workers, media, and online platforms. This move from control to shared management shows the complex, participatory nature of communication in today's networked world.

Kent and Taylor's (2002) theory of CSR highlights that authentic stakeholder relationships depend on dialogue rather than one-way persuasion. Brands must cultivate spaces where diverse voices—consumers, employees, media, and even critics, so that they can engage in open exchange. In this "interactive and collaborative space," meaning is negotiated rather than dictated. Transparency, quick response, and empathy now define reputation-building, replacing old image control. This interactive approach makes branding a constant act of listening, adjusting, and learning with different publics.

Fournier (1998) said an emotional and relational view to branding. Fournier sees brands as relationship partners, not fixed symbols. On social media, people treat brands as living beings—talking, praising, criticising, and reshaping them every day. These exchanges create value that companies can't fully control. So, consumers become active partners in shaping brand identity, not just passive audiences.

Kavaratzis (2005) further argues that in contexts such as place branding, meaning develops through collaboration among governments, businesses, residents, and visitors. This approach reflects shared governance, where brand value arises from dialogue and negotiation among multiple actors. In today’s environment, brands also exist within a “multi-actor public sphere,” where algorithms, influencers, and media rapidly amplify or transform their narratives.

In this shared environment, algorithms work as unseen stakeholders that influence what people notice and engage with. Platform systems decide which brand messages are promoted and which disappear, pushing managers to balance human interaction with algorithmic control. At the same time, employees act as everyday storytellers. Through their words and actions, they shape how the brand appears and feels in culture.

In the end, brand management has turned into brand stewardship — a process of guidance, not control. A brand’s meaning and value grow from the meeting points of human relations, media flows, and algorithmic systems. Understanding this complexity, strong brands act as facilitators of conversation. They build networks of trust and co-creation that reflect shared values instead of imposed stories.

Brands such as Apple and Arc’teryx demonstrate that a brand can be guided but never fully controlled. Managers may design strategies, craft images, and set directions, yet once a brand enters public culture, it becomes part of a shared space. People discuss, remix, and reinterpret its meaning in diverse ways. Consumers contribute personal emotions and experiences, while media and communities add new layers of interpretation. Over time, these collective voices keep the brand evolving, ensuring its meaning remains dynamic rather than fixed.

Apple is often seen as a master of brand control. Its ads, stores, and product designs all share a clear and consistent style — clean, creative, and focused on people. The company carefully shapes every detail to express its “Think Different” spirit. Yet once products reach users, their meanings start to shift. For some, Apple stands for innovation and individuality. For others, it has become a symbol of wealth and status. Online communities add new layers through memes, reviews, and daily discussions. Even criticism — such as complaints about price or the environment — becomes part of what Apple represents. This shows that while Apple can guide its image, it cannot control how people interpret or value it.

Arc'teryx, known as Shizuniao in China, is another strong example. The brand began as a maker of professional outdoor gear focused on performance and function. But on social media platforms like Xiaohongshu and TikTok, its jackets have become a fashion symbol for young urban users. The rise of the “techwear” trend has turned Arc'teryx into a mark of cool, minimalist style rather than just outdoor adventure. While the company can protect its authenticity and promote sustainability, it cannot control how people reinterpret it in different cultures. The public, influencers, and even social media algorithms now work together to shape what the brand means.

However, the Arc’teryx “fireworks event in Tibet” shows the limits of brand control. On September 19, 2025, Arc’teryx worked with artist Cai Guoqiang to hold a fireworks show called “Ascending Dragon” in Shigatse, Tibet, within the Himalayas (See Appendix B). The event was meant to honor nature and show a dialogue between humans and mountains, using fireworks and high-altitude scenery to create a powerful visual effect. However, it quickly caused strong criticism. Many people said the fireworks harmed Tibet’s fragile environment and went against the brand’s image of being eco-friendly (Tencent News, 2025). When videos of the event appeared online, the reaction spread fast. Outdoor lovers, environmentalists, and ordinary users questioned whether it was right to set off fireworks in such a sensitive area. Social media made the issue even bigger. The backlash grew as influencers, media outlets, and algorithms repeated and reshaped the story, turning Arc'teryx from a symbol of sustainability into one of contradiction. Although the company later apologized, the public was still angry, and some even called for boycotts. Reports also said the brand's parent company, Amer Sports, saw drops in market value and problems in sales channels. The company did not plan for such results—it wanted to celebrate nature through art—but once a brand enters the public space, meaning becomes hard to control. This case shows that in today's digital culture, brand communication no longer moves in one direction. Public opinion can change a brand's image faster than managers can respond. To rebuild trust, Arc'teryx needs more than marketing or explanations; it must reflect and engage in honest dialogue. The event is a clear reminder that a brand's meaning is never fixed, it is constantly shaped by people, media, and culture, often in ways the company cannot predict or control. The case demonstrates that cultural backlash can redefine brand meaning faster than managerial communication can respond.

Both cases reveal that a brand exists through interaction. Its meaning emerges within a network of people, stories, and digital spaces. As Holt (2004) and Arvidsson (2005) note, brands function as cultural systems that evolve alongside society. Managers can guide this process through communication and ethical practice, but they cannot fully control it. True brand power comes from connection, not dominance. It grows by listening, learning, and adapting to others. A brand becomes truly strong when it engages with people, embraces change, and allows meaning to develop through shared experience.

A brand can be managed strategically, but its meaning can never be fully controlled. As Keller notes, management can guide brand direction through design, communication, and consistency, but once a brand enters public culture, it becomes a shared social creation. Meaning flows across audiences, communities, and digital spaces, where multiple actors participate in shaping what a brand stands for.

From a cultural perspective, Holt (2004) argues that brands function as cultural systems shaped by stories, symbols, and everyday practice. Their power lies in connection rather than control—the ability to reflect people's values and imagination. Arvidsson (2005) adds that brand value arises from "ethical surplus," created when consumers invest emotion and creativity into a brand. Meaning, therefore, develops through dialogue rather than corporate direction. Similarly, Iglesias et al. (2013) emphasize that strong brands build trust by engaging stakeholders, with managers acting as facilitators rather than controllers.

Real cases show this clearly. Apple manages its design, message, and emotion carefully, but people still read it differently—some see innovation, others see status. Arc'teryx, once known for outdoor gear, became a fashion symbol online, and its Tibet fireworks crisis showed how fast brands lose control when values clash. These cases prove that brand meaning keeps changing through consumers, employees, media, and algorithms.

In short, a brand can be guided but not ruled. Managers can shape tone and strategy, but meaning grows through society's dialogue and reinterpretation. Branding is not control but care—an ongoing exchange between companies and the public. Modern brand management depends on guidance, flexibility, and cultural awareness, not domination.

In conclusion, this essay argues that a brand can be guided but never fully controlled. Branding today is open and social, not something companies own alone. It is shaped by shared participation across culture and community. Holt's (2004) view of brands as cultural systems and Arvidsson's (2005) idea of co-created value show that meaning grows through constant interaction between companies, consumers, media, and digital platforms. Similarly, Iglesias et al. (2013) see brands as living systems that develop through dialogue, not command. Cases like Apple and Arc'teryx show the mix of control and co-creation. Apple builds a clear image, but people still give it new meanings through use, humor, and criticism. Arc'teryx lost control during the Tibet fireworks event, showing that once a brand enters public culture, meanings spread far beyond what the company intends.

For researchers, this shows that brands should be seen as living systems that change with culture and technology. For managers, it means that success today needs openness—listening, talking with people, and adjusting to shared meanings instead of fighting them. In the end, the question "Can a brand really be managed?" has a clear answer: a brand can be guided, but never fully controlled.

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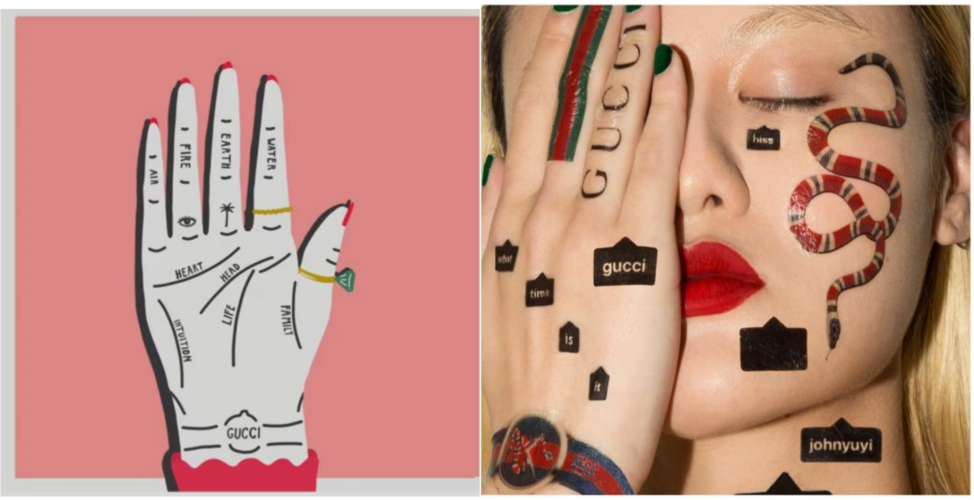
Appendix

Appendix A:



Source: Gucci, 2017, #TFWGucci, Available at: https://www.gucci.com/us/en/st/stories/inspirations-and-codes/article/spring_summer_2017_tfw_gucci_meme/ (Accessed: 26 October 2025)

Appendix B:

Source: Li, 2025, The controversy over the Arc'teryx fireworks incident continues to escalate. Lianhe News, Available at: https://www.zaobao.com.sg/news/china/story20250921-7547903? (Accessed: 26 October 2025)